



offence.”

As it turned out, the increasingly versatile Sinner did both. He supplemented his vaunted power and precision with drop shots, serve-and-volleys, super angles, and opportunistic forays to the net to intercept floating returns. In other words, he played more like Alcaraz than ever before.

That new-found panache added to his crowd appeal. They sang in delight when their hero belted an ace to hold serve for 2-all. After Sinner won a 24-shot power point for 3-all, 40-30, he put his finger to his ear to encourage more applause. They rejoiced again when Sinner staved off a set point at 5-6, 30-40 with an audacious 116-mph second serve that Alcaraz couldn't return.

On to the tiebreak, where Sinner enjoyed a terrific 15-3 record this year compared with 16-9 for Alcaraz. But the Spaniard led 3-1 in their matches. Oddly enough, clever lobs by Sinner made much of the difference in winning the 7-4

tiebreak. He lofted a disguised lob that forced a weak counter-lob by Alcaraz, which Sinner smashed for a winner and a 5-3 lead.

Two points later, Sinner climaxed a 17-shot power rally with a beautiful forehand lob winner to go ahead 6-4. The crowd roared in appreciation. Alcaraz's forehand serve return landed deep to clinch the 7-6 set.

When the oddsmakers made Sinner an 89 per cent favourite to win the match before the second set, the prescient Courier said, “I guarantee you Sinner doesn't feel that confident.”

Sinner double-faulted twice and erred on two forehands to suffer his first break in 47 service games in the tournament. Sinner broke back for 3-all, but it took a little luck. He mishit a vicious body serve, and the fluke floated and landed deep in the court. He then returned Alcaraz's shot with a super-angled forehand drop-shot winner.

Serving at 5-6, Alcaraz hit a forehand for 15-love and flashed his

Elite performance: Elena Rybakina beat World No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka to win her maiden WTA Finals title. AFP

trademark smile. But at crunch time, 40-40, Alcaraz netted a low backhand volley and then stroked a backhand wide. Game, set, and title: Sinner 7-6(4), 7-5.

Sinner collapsed onto his back to celebrate his triumph, and then the good friends smiled as they embraced at the net. After scampering to his ecstatic Player Box to hug his team, Sinner graciously praised his arch-rival as the crowd cheered for both champions.

“Carlos, amazing season. Well-deserved for your No. 1 [ranking]. You really deserve it. Amazing, what you're doing with the whole team. You're definitely a player I look up to.”

Alcaraz reciprocated, telling the crowd, “You were cheering for Sinner most of the time, but you were respectful. Thank you, Torino.” The